Murtajapur/Murtijapur is in Maharashtra (Akola district) and is a junction in Bhusawal division of Central Railway (CR), along the main Mumbai-Nagpur-Howrah broad gauge line. However, a narrow gauge line also passes through Murtazapur, divided into a 76–km northern stretch between Murtazapur and Achalpur/Ellichpur and a 113–km south-eastern stretch between Murtazapur and Yeotmal/Yavatmal.

The Yavatmal stretch was opened in 1903 and Achalpur stretch in 1913. Both segments were constructed and operated by the Great Indian Peninsula Railway (GIPR). In 1925, GIPR became a part of the Indian Railways. Therefore, as a legacy, the Indian Railways started to operate narrow gauge trains along the Shakuntala Railway (the train is known as Shakuntala Express).

Locomotives were initially steam ones, replaced with diesel in 1995. The ageing old infrastructure is still in use and evokes a sense of nostalgia.

Shakuntala Railway is still owned by CPRC, presumably because the government of the day simply forgot to nationalize it. The CPRC and Killick Nixon have moved from British to Indian hands.

There is a contract between CPRC and the Central Railway (CR) under which the CPRC can keep 55 per cent of passenger revenue, giving the rest to CR. Naturally, CPRC is meant to maintain rail tracks. But it doesn't possess the resources and the CR has refused to pay it, since they have been spending on its maintenance. The result is a judicial dispute. [152]

Interestingly, the CRPC is now based in Borivali, Mumbai, and the company's 107th Annual Report states that the Central Railway had demanded a sum of ₹18.72 crore in December 2002 towards repairs, rehabilitation, renewals and replacements of the railway assets.

The Indian Railways have, meanwhile, listed the line to be converted into a main line broad gauge and the line, as it existed, is set to become history for ever.

THE SECOND COMING

Do trains have life? If they do, the one I am going to talk about has had its rebirth. And that too, a glorious one. One Electric Multiple Unit (EMU) railway coach has shown how invincible the Indian Railways are in letter and spirit.